the case of a US-sponsored Pacific Pact and SEATO, he emphasized his lack of interest in what he interpreted as Zhou's suggestion for a grouping of Southeast Asian countries; instead, he urged the premier to pursue bilateral understandings with Southeast Asian countries to reassure them.[122] Nehru would later also resist visiting Beijing at the same time as Burmese prime minister U Nu, in case that was misconstrued as the beginnings of an anti-SEATO alliance.[123]

US intelligence analysts saw Zhou's visits to India and Burma as part of a Chinese effort to split the noncommunist countries, "dull the[ir] vigilance," and buy time. Simultaneously, they believed Beijing would continue to subvert noncommunist regimes and build up Chinese military capability.[124] After the visit, Allen and his Canadian counterpart worried that Nehru had bought China's "peaceful intentions" line. The American ambassador lamented that as long as Nehru had "blind faith" in China's good intentions, he would not even help guarantee Burma's security—let alone do more.[125] There was also concern about the impact on the Indian public's perceptions of China and the US. In India, Zhou had publicly offered reassurances about China's intentions, while explaining Chinese concern about American encirclement and regime change efforts, "thus endeavoring to avert [a] picture of China as aggressor to [a] picture of China as [a] victim of United States aggressive designs."[126]

Pillai, in turn, assessed that Zhou's trip had been designed to reassure India, and also to show Beijing's independence from Moscow.[127] After the visit, Nehru admitted that Zhou's assurances could have been part of a "clever strategy looking to the distant future."[128] Nonetheless, at that point he was convinced that Chinese leaders did not want war because it would disrupt their efforts to improve conditions within China. The only thing, he believed, that would provoke them was fear of attack. He was impressed by Zhou's questions about what might reassure Southeast Asian countries. He perceived the lack of an attack on Burma—even though Guomindang (GMD) operations from there gave Beijing an excuse—as evidence of China's desire for peace.[129] Asked by an American correspondent about Zhou's continued insistence that China had the right to use force to take Taiwan, Nehru said he disagreed with that contention, but dismissed it as directed toward a domestic audience.[130]